Proposal for Emoji: Kidney

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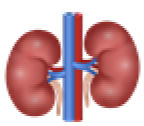
Required Example Images

Color 18x18:

Color 72x72:



Black-and-white 18x18:

Black-and-white 72x72:

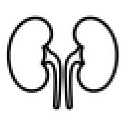


Image License And Rights

The color kidney artwork was created for the Medical Emoji project by Alla Shamanska for ConductScience. ConductScience owns the color artwork and authorizes its use in this Unicode emoji proposal.

The black-and-white reference images were generated by the Medical Emoji team using GPT image generation as simplified proposal reference artwork. The submitter will confirm final authorization and agree to the Unicode Emoji Proposal Agreement and License before filing:

https://www.unicode.org/emoji/emoji-proposal-agreement.pdf

1. Identification

Suggested name: Kidney

Suggested keywords: renal; organ; anatomy; body; urine; filtration; hydration; bean; bean-shaped; stone; health; nephrology; dialysis; transplant; donation; chronic disease; acute injury

Suggested category: People & Body, body-parts.

Suggested sort location: after `lungs` in the body-parts subgroup.

Unicode emoji list and ordering reference: https://www.unicode.org/emoji/charts/emoji-list.html

The proposed name is `Kidney`. The singular name is the clearest ordinary-language label and is likely to match user search behavior better than `Kidneys`. Vendor artwork could depict a pair of kidneys if that proves more recognizable at emoji size, but the encoded name should remain broad, concise, and easy to find.

2. Images

The proposal includes the required color and black-and-white example images at both 18x18 and 72x72 pixels at the top of the first page. The image represents paired kidneys with vessels and ureters so that the design reads as an anatomical organ rather than a bean. The image is a reference image for vendors, not a request for exact vendor artwork.

Artwork source: https://medicalemoji.org/images/emoji/kidneysnew2.png

Black-and-white source note: the black-and-white 18x18 and 72x72 example images are simplified reference images generated by the Medical Emoji team using GPT image generation for this proposal. They are included as proposal reference artwork, not as required vendor art.

Essential Visual Cues

The example image is a paradigm image, not a request for exact vendor artwork. To remain recognizable at emoji size, vendor renderings should preserve the core kidney concept through a paired internal-organ form, curved kidney shape, medial indentation, and a simple indication of vessels or ureters. The image should not read primarily as a food bean, a generic red organ, a logo, or a text-bearing medical icon.

Vendor variation is expected. Vendors may simplify internal details, adjust color, vary the degree of anatomical realism, or use a compact paired-organ rendering as long as the result remains recognizably kidney-related at small sizes.

Visual cue	Importance	Reason
Paired organ presentation	Strongly preferred	Helps avoid confusion with a single bean or generic red shape.
Curved kidney shape with medial indentation	Required	Carries the core anatomical silhouette.
Ureters or simple downward connectors	Strongly preferred	Signals urinary-system anatomy and distinguishes the image from a food bean.
Red, brown, or organ-like color	Optional	Vendors can vary palette if the shape remains legible.
Fine vascular detail	Optional	Can be simplified or removed at 18x18.

3. Factors For Inclusion

A. Multiple Concepts

The kidney emoji represents a broad, durable, and widely understood concept rather than a single diagnosis, procedure, campaign, or profession. People use the word `kidney` in ordinary life for the body part, kidney beans, kidney-shaped objects, anatomy lessons, hydration, filtration, body functions, wellness, diet, cooking, donation, transplant, stones, urine, and health.

The everyday case comes first. A kidney emoji would support ordinary communication about the human body, school science, food and recipes, body-function jokes, hydration reminders, fitness and wellness conversations, family health updates, donor and transplant conversations, patient education, and public-health messages. It would not be limited to clinicians, nephrology groups, or awareness campaigns.

The kidney bean is a useful example of the word's everyday reach. The proposal is not arguing that an anatomical kidney emoji should replace the existing bean emoji for food. Instead, the kidney bean shows that the kidney shape and name are already familiar outside clinical settings. People recognize the term in grocery, cooking, recipe, and nutrition contexts, as well as in phrases such as kidney-shaped pool, kidney-shaped table, kidney stone, kidney donor, kidney function, and kidney health.

The concept also works metaphorically. Kidneys are commonly understood as filters and regulators: they clean, balance, process, and remove waste. Those functions make the emoji useful for non-specialist expressions about filtering, cleansing, hydration, balance, body maintenance, and checking whether something is functioning properly. These are plain-language associations, not narrow medical jargon.

Current public-health sources support the durability of the concept without replacing the everyday usage case. WHO describes kidney disease as including acute kidney injury and chronic kidney disease, estimates that 674 million people have chronic kidney disease worldwide, and notes that kidney failure requires dialysis or kidney transplantation to sustain life:

https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/kidney-disease

The 2025 Lancet Global Burden of Disease analysis estimated that, in 2023, 788 million adults aged 20 years and older had chronic kidney disease and that chronic kidney disease was the ninth leading cause of death globally:

https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736(25)01853-7

CDC's 2026 United States summary estimates that more than 1 in 10 adults aged 18 or older, approximately 37 million people, have chronic kidney disease:

https://www.cdc.gov/kidney-disease/php/data-research/index.html

These health sources are not substitutes for Unicode's required frequency evidence. They explain one important part of the concept's durability, but the proposal's multiple-concepts case is broader: body part, everyday word, food association, recognizable shape, education, wellness, filtration, donation, and health communication.

B. Use In Sequences

The kidney emoji would work as a building block with existing emoji to convey additional concepts without requiring new standardized sequences.

Message context	Possible emoji composition
Hydration reminder, urine production, or filtration	Kidney plus droplet.
Kidney beans, chili, meal planning, or nutrition	Kidney plus bowl, cooking pot, or bean.
Anatomy class or school science	Kidney plus book, school, or microscope.
Donor, recipient, patient, clinician, caregiver, or family update	Kidney plus person, family, or hospital.
Medication safety or kidney-function monitoring	Kidney plus pill.
Kidney stone warning, urgent symptoms, or abnormal lab concern	Kidney plus warning sign.
Transplant preparation or post-transplant care	Kidney plus hospital, person, or syringe.

These are ordinary emoji-composition examples. This proposal does not request a standardized ZWJ sequence.

C. Breaks New Ground

Kidney would add a distinct internal-organ concept that is not currently represented by existing emoji. Existing emoji can imply health care in general, such as hospital, pill, syringe, drop, anatomical heart, lungs, and brain, but none directly represents kidney anatomy, kidney function, kidney disease, dialysis, kidney transplant, living donation, kidney stones, acute kidney injury, or kidney-specific medication safety.

The proposal does not depend on the argument that heart, lungs, or brain already exist. Those emoji are useful context, but the kidney case stands on independent grounds: the kidney is a globally important organ concept with public-health salience, broad everyday and clinical uses, and several communication contexts that existing emoji cannot express clearly.

Current substitutes fail in predictable ways:

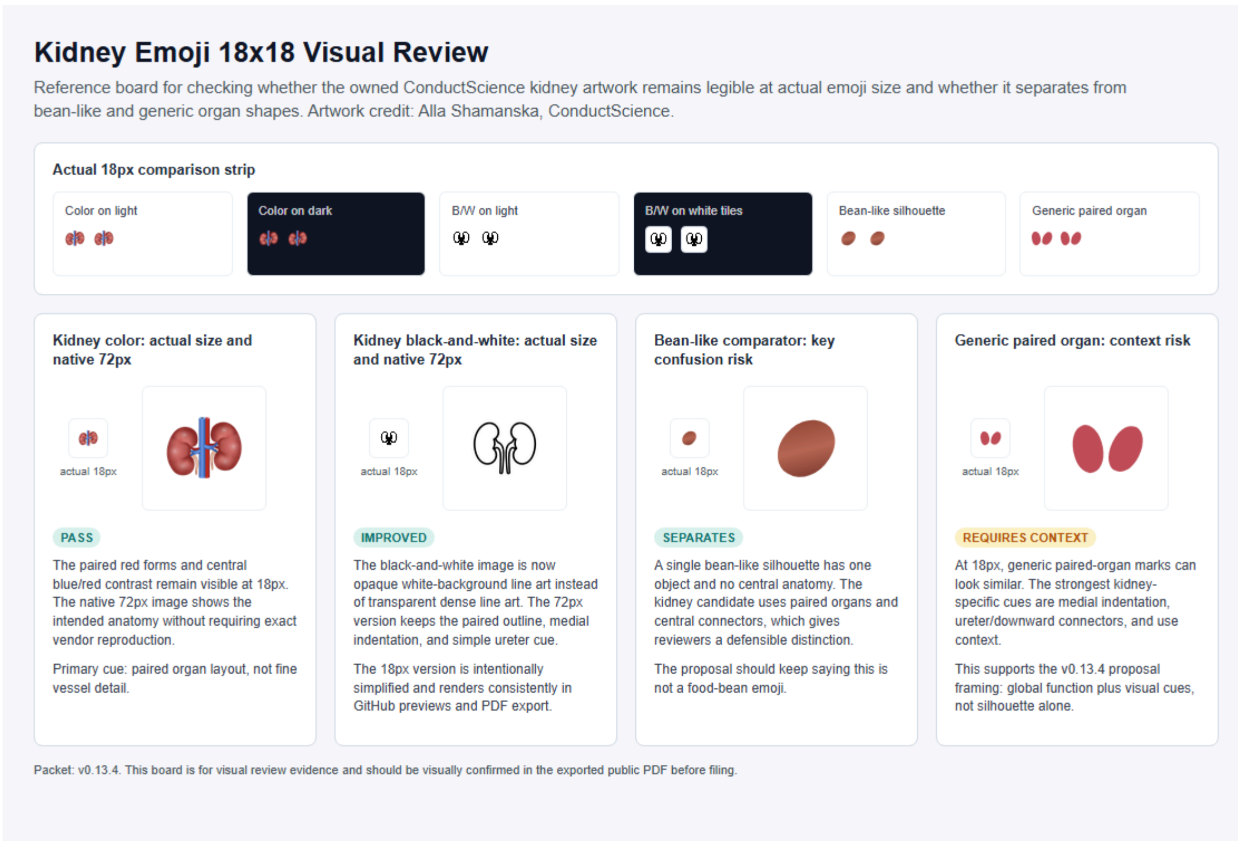
Existing emoji or sequence	**Why it is insufficient**
Bean	Primarily food; wrong tone for anatomy, donor, transplant, patient, and clinical communication.
Droplet	Can mean water, sweat, tears, blood, or urine; does not identify kidney anatomy or kidney function.
Hospital	Identifies a place or institution, not an organ, body function, symptom, or donor/transplant concept.
Pill	Identifies medication or treatment, not kidney anatomy, kidney function, kidney stones, or kidney donation.
Syringe	Suggests injection, vaccination, blood draw, or procedure; does not identify kidney.
Anatomical heart, lungs, or brain	Different organs with different meanings; cannot substitute for kidney-specific communication.
Warning sign plus medical emoji	Indicates risk or urgency, but still does not tell the reader that the topic is kidney-related.

The global and universal case is functional and contextual. Across countries and health systems, kidneys are associated with filtering blood, producing urine, kidney-function testing, dialysis, transplantation, donation, kidney stones, diabetes, hypertension, medication safety, and chronic disease. Those concepts recur in patient education, public-health campaigns, clinical care, organ donation systems, and everyday health conversations even when the exact local illustration style varies.

D. Distinctiveness

The kidney has a recognizable anatomical form in medical education: a curved organ shape, a medial indentation, vessels, ureters, and a common paired-organ presentation. The proposal acknowledges that kidney is less universally iconic than symbols such as a heart. That is why the proposed image uses a paired anatomical presentation with vessels and ureters rather than relying on a single bean-like silhouette.

The proposal includes an 18x18 visual review board comparing the kidney rendering against the bean emoji and current anatomical emoji.



The current paired-kidney image is the preferred direction because it makes the concept more universal: users do not need specialist anatomical knowledge to infer that the image represents a pair of internal organs connected to the urinary system.

Distinctiveness question	Proposal answer
Could it be confused with the bean emoji?	The paired organ form, indentation, and ureter connectors distinguish it from a single food bean.
Could it be confused with anatomical heart, lungs, or brain?	The curved paired shape and downward connectors are different from those organ silhouettes.
Does it require exact vendor art?	No. Vendors may simplify the vessels and color treatment if the paired kidney shape remains clear.
Does it work at 18x18?	The included visual review board tests the proposed paradigm at emoji size against nearby confusable emoji.

E. Expected Usage Level

Expected usage is supported by public search-result, video-result, search-interest, image-search-interest, and corpus evidence. The Trends and Ngram figures compare `kidney` with `elephant`.

Evidence source	Query	Captured result	Reproducible URL
Google Search	`kidney`	About 211,000,000 results	https://www.google.com/search?q=kidney&hl=en&num=10&pws=0
Google Video Search	`kidney`	About 66,000,000 results	https://www.google.com/search?tbm=vid&q=kidney&hl=en&num=10&pws=0
Google Trends Web Search	`elephant,kidney`	Screenshot included below	https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all&q=elephant,kidney
Google Trends Image Search	`elephant,kidney`	Screenshot included below	https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all_2008&gprop=images&q=elephant,kidney
Google Books Ngram Viewer	`elephant,kidney`	Screenshot included below	https://books.google.com/ngrams/graph?content=elephant%2Ckidney&year_start=1500&year_end=2019&corpus=en-2019&smoothing=3

Figure 1. Google Search results for `kidney`:

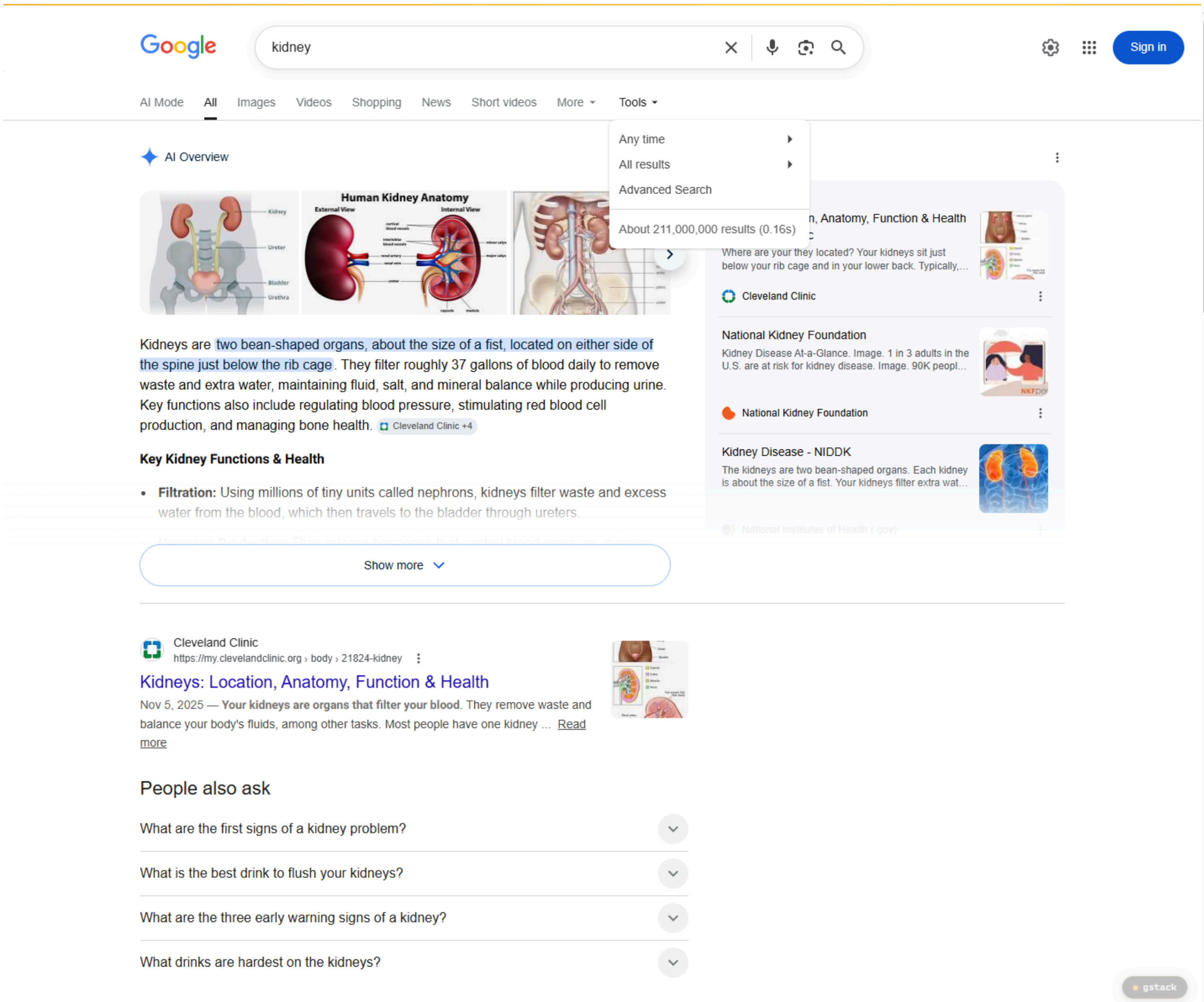


Figure 2. Google Video Search results for `kidney`:

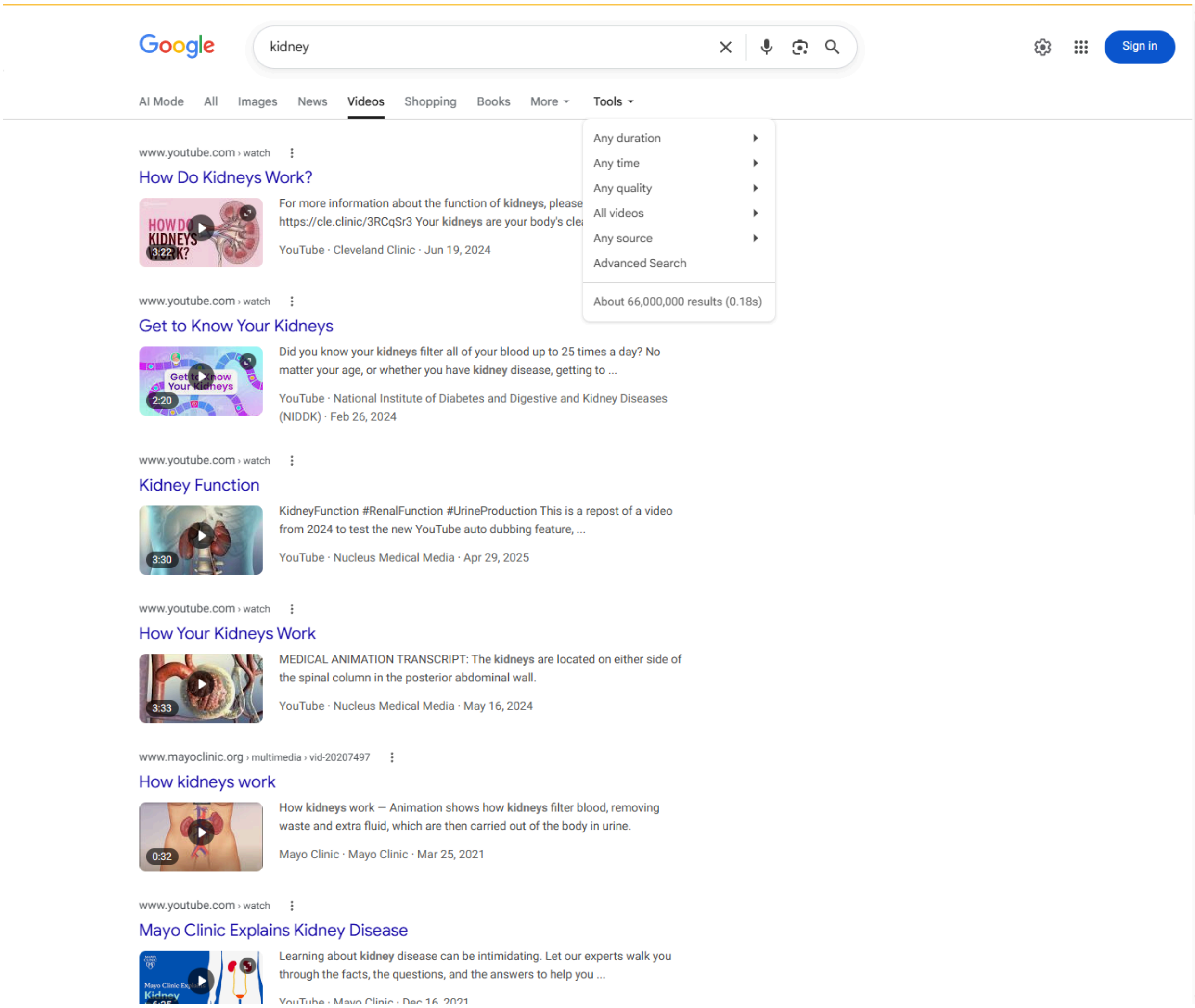


Figure 3. Google Trends Web Search, `elephant` versus `kidney`:

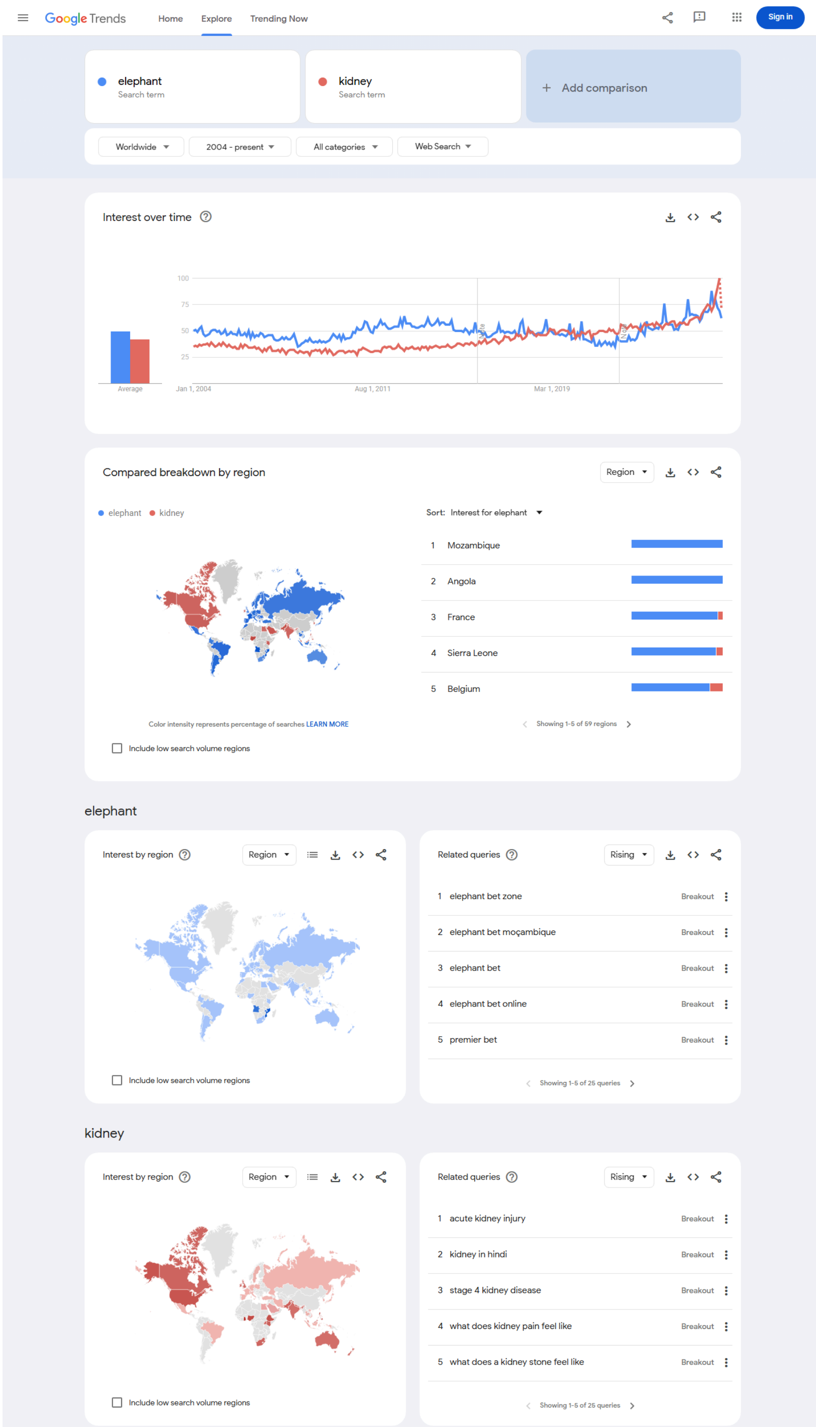


Figure 4. Google Trends Image Search, `elephant` versus `kidney`:

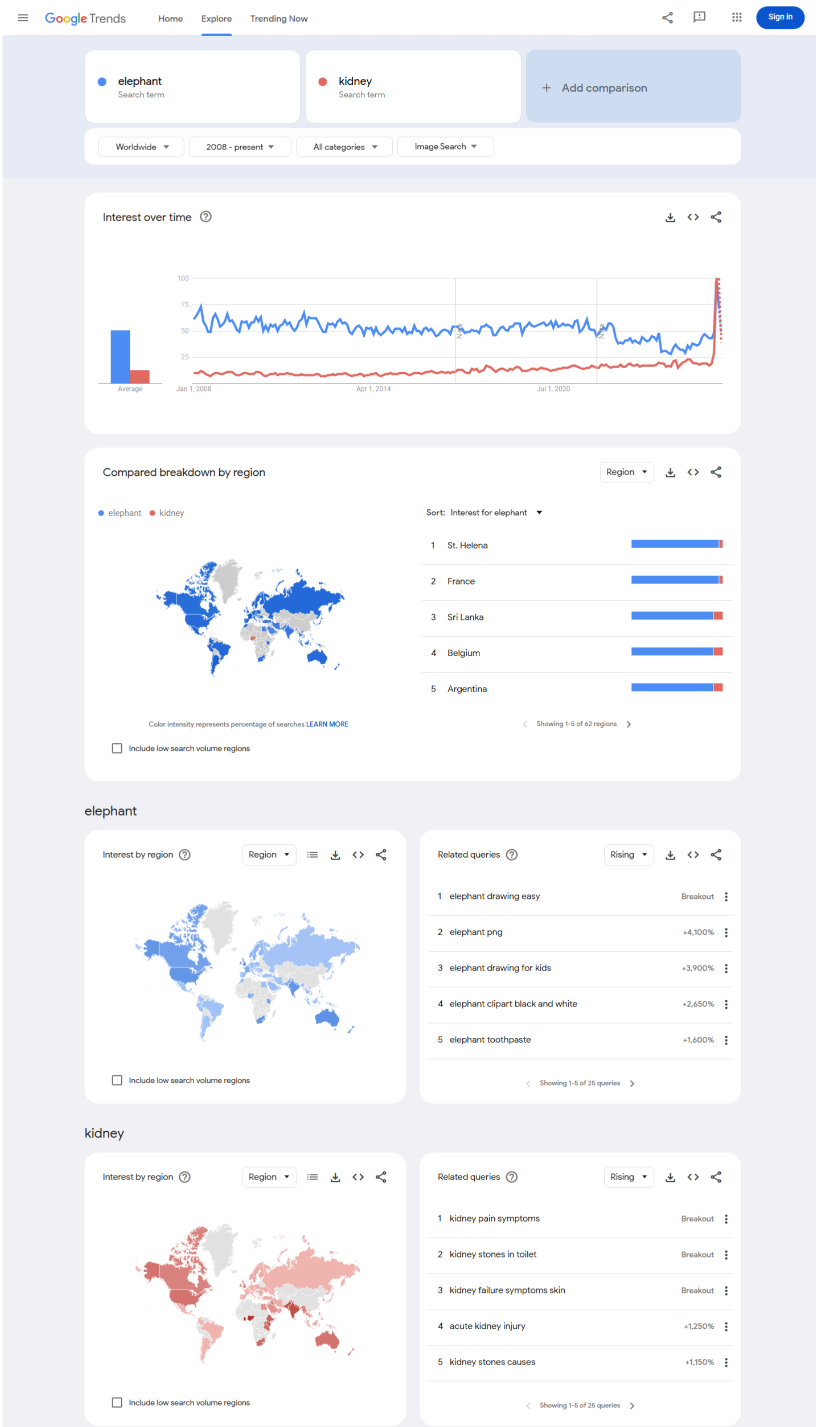
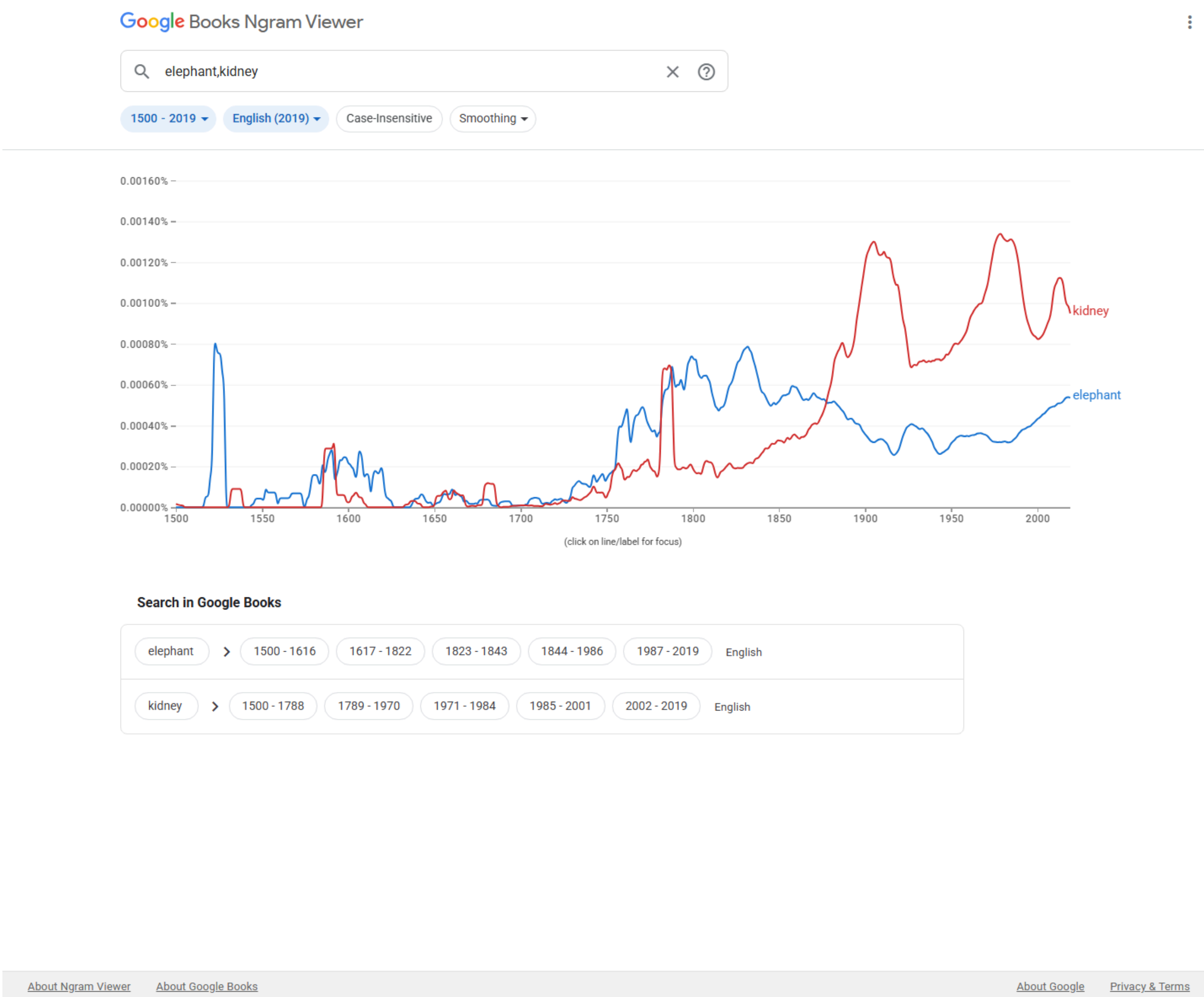


Figure 5. Google Books Ngram Viewer, `elephant` versus `kidney`:



F. Completeness

Kidney would help fill a practical gap in the limited set of emoji available for major human anatomy and health communication, but the proposal is not asking Unicode to encode every organ. Kidney has independent grounds for consideration because it is associated with a broad set of durable, common concepts: kidney health, kidney disease, kidney failure, dialysis, transplant, donation, kidney stones, urine production, filtration, acute kidney injury, medication safety, diabetes, hypertension, and global public health.

G. Compatibility

No compatibility claim is currently made. The proposal does not rely on an existing kidney pictograph in a legacy carrier set or another major communication system. If a documented high-usage kidney pictograph is found before submission, this section can be updated with the source and evidence. Otherwise, compatibility should be treated as not applicable.

4. Factors For Exclusion

A. Already Represented

Kidney is not already represented by existing emoji. General medical emoji such as hospital, pill, syringe, and drop can support some kidney-related messages, but they do not identify the kidney. Anatomical heart, lungs, and brain represent different organs and cannot substitute for kidney-specific contexts. The bean emoji is also not an adequate substitute because it represents food and can cause ambiguity in clinical, transplant, donor, public-health, anatomy, and body-function communication.

B. Overly Specific

Kidney is not overly specific. It is a primary human organ and a broad public-health concept. The proposal is not for a particular disease subtype, treatment brand, advocacy organization, medical specialty logo, campaign ribbon, or procedure. A kidney emoji would cover many contexts across anatomy, physiology, disease, treatment, symptoms, transplant, donation, and everyday health conversations.

C. Open-Ended

The proposal does not ask Unicode to create a complete anatomy taxonomy. Kidney is proposed because it meets a bounded set of independent criteria rather than because it is one item in an open-ended organ list.

Criterion	Kidney evidence
High public frequency	Google Search, Google Video Search, Google Trends Web Search, Google Trends Image Search, and Google Books Ngram Viewer evidence are included in this proposal.
Broad ordinary-language use	Kidney is used for the body part, kidney beans, kidney-shaped objects, hydration, filtration, stones, donation, transplant, and school science.
Global and durable concept	Kidney function, kidney disease, dialysis, transplantation, diabetes, hypertension, donation, and medication safety recur across countries and health systems.
Not clearly substitutable	Bean, droplet, hospital, pill, syringe, heart, lungs, and brain all fail in different contexts.
Visually testable	Paired kidney shape, medial indentation, vessels, and ureters can be tested at 18x18.

If future organ proposals are submitted, they should be judged on their own usage evidence, distinctiveness, and expressive value. This proposal does not argue that every organ should become an emoji.

D. Transient

Kidney is not transient. Kidney health, kidney disease, kidney stones, kidney failure, dialysis, transplantation, living donation, diabetes, hypertension, medication safety, and acute kidney injury are enduring topics. The proposed emoji is not tied to a temporary event, a single campaign year, or a trend.

E. Justified By An Existing Emoji

This proposal is not justified solely by comparison with existing emoji. The existence of anatomical heart, lungs, or brain can show that anatomical concepts can be represented as emoji, but it does not itself justify kidney. The kidney proposal is based on the organ's own broad meanings, expected usage, visual distinctiveness, public-health relevance, and inability to be represented clearly by existing emoji.

5. Other Information

A. Public-Health And Clinical Context

Kidney-related communication often requires plain, patient-facing language. A simple kidney emoji could make kidney health, transplant, donation, dialysis, testing, hydration, urine, medication safety, and chronic disease messages easier to scan and recognize in ordinary digital communication. This is especially relevant because kidney disease may be asymptomatic until late stages and because kidney failure requires dialysis or transplantation to sustain life.

The proposal does not claim that an emoji will directly improve clinical outcomes. The more defensible claim is that the kidney is a high-utility concept in health communication, patient advocacy, public education, and everyday discussion.

B. Coalition And Support Materials

The Medical Emoji project has recovered public support materials from nephrology, patient-advocacy, and kidney-health organizations. These letters demonstrate expert and patient-advocacy support, but the expected-usage case in Section 3.E is based on public frequency evidence rather than support letters, petitions, hashtags, or social-media requests.

Supplemental support-letter links:

American Association of Kidney Patients: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/AAKP-Kidney-Emoji-Letter-1.7.22.pdf

American Society of Nephrology: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/kidney-support-letters/ASN_Long-2.pdf

American Society of Diagnostic and Interventional Nephrology: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/kidney-support-letters/ASDIN.pdf

Canadian Society of Nephrology: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/Kidney_Emoji_Letter-1.pdf

Glomerular Disease Study and Trial Consortium / GlomCon: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/kidney-support-letters/Glomcon.pdf

International Society of Nephrology: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/kidney-support-letters/ISN.pdf

Kidney Disease: Improving Global Outcomes: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/The-Unicode-Consortium_Signed.pdf

National Kidney Foundation: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/kidney-support-letters/NKF-1.pdf

NephJC: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/NephJC_KidneyEmoji.pdf

Renal Physicians Association: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/kidney-support-letters/RPA.pdf

Kidney Foundation of Western New York: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/Kidney-Foundation-of-WNY-kidney-emoji-letter.pdf

Women Nephrology India: https://medicalemoji.org/documents/Kidney-Emoji-WIN-Letter-Head-V4B-converted.docx